

of horizontal viewing space for your eyes! However, the bright green power LED disturbs especially when working in the dark—it's simply too bright; thankfully, it's not red or even blue! This is common to nearly all ViewSonics.

Acer's AL1706 attracted attention, and held it—it's built on the same slim, ultra narrow bezel, attractive lines as the AL1906 but unlike its larger sibling, there weren't as many show stoppers.

Visually, Dell's 1707FP has to get top honours—the stands are absolutely amazing, and we couldn't figure out how such a slim stand could hold the monitor stably. And stable it was—even more so than some models with bases that occupied double the surface area. Dell also has some of the narrowest bezels around—and this makes for great dual-monitor setups with hardly any gap between screens. Samsung's 740N also has a narrow bezel, though the round stand is a bit ugly.

Intex also makes attractive monitors and their 1703 is no exception, but it sports a bulky power adapter. This is an unnecessary headache—why bundle an adapter when it can be built in? It certainly doesn't add too much bulk, as we've seen from the other LCDs. Samsung's 713BM Plus has its menu buttons positioned on the bottom of the monitor's bezel, and accessing them is a royal pain.

## The Numbers Game

When it came to pure performance, figures were close, but two monitors fought harder than the rest for pole position. The position for top performer jockeyed back and forth between ASUS' PM17TX and Samsung's 713BM Plus,

**ViewSonic VA1703W**  
I'm 17-inches wide!



| Contact Sheet |                                   | LCD Monitors    |                              |
|---------------|-----------------------------------|-----------------|------------------------------|
| Brand         | Company                           | Phone           | E-mail                       |
| Acer          | Acer India Pvt Ltd                | 080 - 25219520  | alankar_s@acer.co.in         |
| AOC           | AOC India                         | 1800 425 4318   | info@in.aocmonitor.com       |
| ASUS          | ASUS Technology Pvt. Ltd          | 022 - 4005 8888 | media_india@asus.com         |
| BenQ          | BenQ India Pvt Ltd                | 9312378705      | Sales.EnquiryIn@BenQ.com     |
| Dell          | Dell Computers Asia Pte Ltd       | 080-2506-8026   | NA                           |
| HP            | Rashi Peripherals                 | 22-67090909     | navinderc@rptechindia.com    |
| Intex         | Intex Technologies                | 011-30888919    | sanjay@intextechnologies.com |
| Jetway        | Rashi Peripherals                 | 22-67090909     | navinderc@rptechindia.com    |
| LG            | LG Electronics India Pvt Ltd      | 9899302074      | avarshney@lgindia.com        |
| NEC           | SHIBA COMP.PVT.LTD                | 011-30822106    | sales@shibacom.com           |
| Samsung       | Samsung India Electronics Pvt Ltd | 011-41511234    | rengith.nair@samsung.com     |
| ViewSonic     | Roop Electronics                  | 022-26681921    | umang@rooponline.com         |

with Dell's 1707FP watching from a close third.

Right on the 1707FP's heels snapped Acer's AL1706, BenQ's FP71G+, LG 1732S and both the ViewSonics. Despite its success, the PM17TX from ASUS wasn't without issues—there was moiré present in the coarse grained tests. The Samsung 713BM Plus didn't have any issues; unfortunately the price (Rs 19,000) will scare away most customers before they even switch it on! Considering it's a TN panel-based monitor, Samsung should seriously consider revising its price.

Samsung's other offering in this category—the 740N—was way behind the leaders' line of sight. Though priced well, it has issues with black levels and contrast ratio. This was noticeable with improper transitions in shade intensity in the 256-colour test. Certain shades of gray had some noise as well—minute, but noticeable. We don't recommend this monitor for anything more than browsing and office work like documents and spreadsheets.

Both Acer's AL1706 and BenQ's FP71G+ caused us no concern throughout the tests. While they weren't the best monitors performance wise, they didn't have any mentionable issues, and if the price of the Samsung 713BM Plus and the ASUS PM17TX is a cause for concern, these two are for the frugal at heart—Rs 11,000 and Rs 10,800 respectively.

Shockingly, one of the cheapest monitors in the test also performs quite well, closely tailing its betters. We're talking about the AOC 177V, which at Rs 9,800 breaks the 10,000-Rupee barrier. Other sub-10,000 models weren't so hot on performance—especially Jetway's 1741S and Intex's 1703. ViewSonic's VA1703W is sub-10,000 in the strictest sense of the word (Rs 9,999), and also performed commendably. In fact, it managed to out-distance its non-widescreen sibling, the VA703M, reversing the results of the 19-inch tests, where the non-widescreen VG921M kayos its widescreen sibling (the VA1912W) with no apparent effort.

## Decision Time

If anything, the contest here was even more fiercely fought than in the 19-inch category; victories weren't clean, and all sides drew blood. AOC made a clean sweep with top honours and takes *Digit's Best Buy Gold* in the 17-inch category as well. Their champion, the 177V, is a winning combination of price and performance. The Silver goes to the sole widescreen in this category—the ViewSonic VA1703. ■

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## Are 8-bit Panels Worth It?

As we mentioned in *Enter The Matrix*, *Digit* March 2006, there are four types of LCD panels being mass produced (though not in equal numbers) today—TN, S-IPS, MVA and PVA. TN panels are by far the cheapest to produce and to buy. These are typically 6-bit panels—6-bits for each colour, which translates to a total of 262,144 colours. However, by a method called dithering (basically interpolation) manufacturers reach the magical figure of 24 bits i.e. 16.7 million colours.

S-IPS and PVA panels are native 8-bit panels, so colour rendition is always superior. MVA panels are the middlemen—they can use dithering, or be native 24-bit.

We have already established that professionals working with images and rendering should avoid 6-bit panels. Another problem inherent to TN panels is the inferior viewing angles. Manufacturers' quotes for viewing angles are not always accurate, simply because the methods employed to measure viewing angles differ.

In our test, we noticed severe issues with viewing angles (vertical in particular) with almost all the 6-bit TN panels.

As the adage goes, all major problems are solved by financial convenience. This is true here as well—TN panels are available in abundance and cheaper by a fair amount than MVA or PVA panels of the same size (S-IPS panels are the costliest). In India, more than 90 percent of all LCD models available are 6-bit panels—8-bit panels are mostly reserved for the 20.1-inch and larger categories. This means that anyone for a 17- or 19-inch LCD will have no option but to go 6-bit.

This said, the difference in price is worth the premium you pay for these higher-quality panels, but if (and only if) you plan on using your monitor for digital entertainment or for professional graphics work.